traditions, seemed more interested in calling out the selective application of such supposedly universal standards. For some reason, they would not question the application of the Western-normative framework that refused to accommodate Indic thought. Critically, the ontological and theological origins of this framework and their effect on non-Western civilisations, such as Bharat, did not seem to get the scrutiny and examination they warranted.

What piqued my attention was that the reservoir of colonial stereotypes about the Indic civilisation, which seemingly opposing sides (or ‘wings’) dipped into and drew from liberally, pun intended, was the same. While one reinforced the stereotypes to make the case that there existed no connection whatsoever between Bharat and India, the other highlighted the very same stereotypes to make its case for a ‘liberal’ Bharat, a new idea of India, if you will, citing Bharat’s innate openness to new ideas and ‘reform’. The former, at least, wore its antipathy to the Indic consciousness openly on its sleeve; the message that was being evangelised by the latter was a repackaged version of the Reformation, in this case, an Indic Reformation. Of course, the latter school of thought pursued its Reformist agenda while paying lip-service to Bharat and its civilisational character to placate the larger Indic society with tokenism. This was a critical layer in the national discourse which needed to be unpacked, in my opinion, since the larger goals of reclaiming Indic civilisational consciousness and agency over it were being relegated to the margins by both sides, albeit for different reasons. The net result was the same—Bharat would continue to operate within the coloniser’s framework, while its civilisational character would be put to symbolic and ornamental use without any real and lasting impact on policymaking.

To me, this did not bode well even for Bharat’s economic aspirations since the premise of an Indic Renaissance, that is, a re-inscription of indigenous consciousness onto contemporary Bharat, was that it was not necessary for Bharat to play by the West’s rules in order to achieve economic prosperity. On the contrary, I believed that a civilisational reclamation had the potential to spur confidence and originality of thought, thereby paving the way for economic progress in a way that was consistent with Indic ethos, which valued a balanced approach to nature and development. Critically, the pursuit of economic prosperity through the mere imitation of a Western framework, according to me, would cement the notion that the only viable way was the Western way, which would have